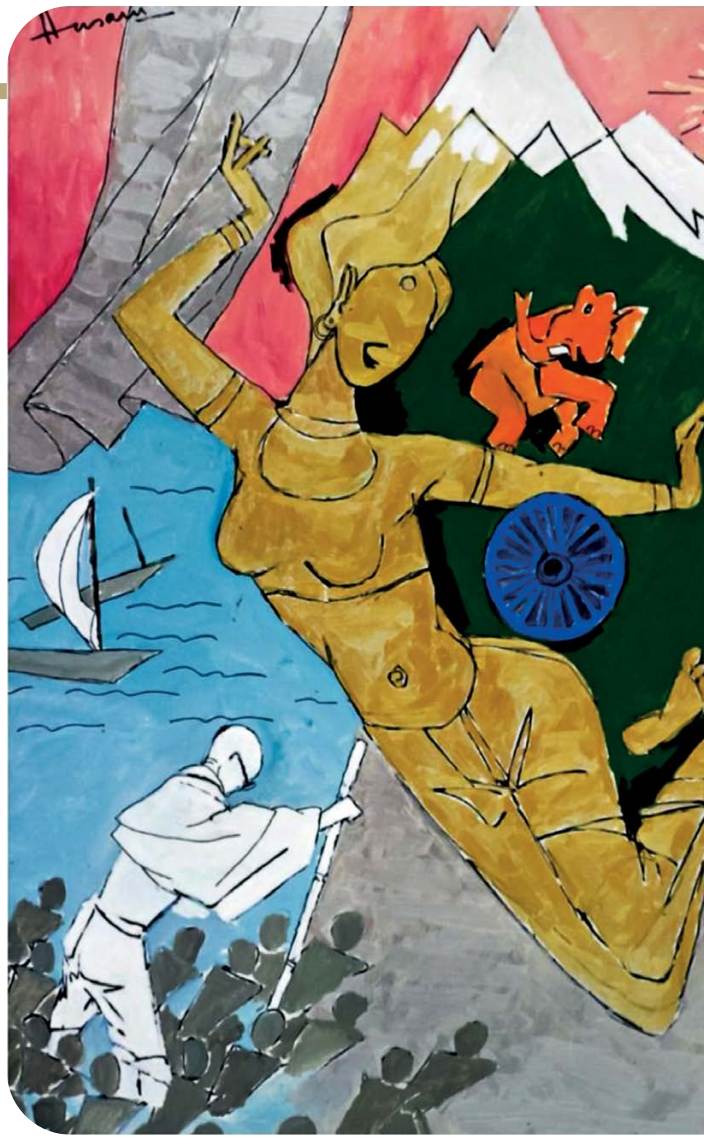
I have known India with a very deep insight," says the handwritten caption at the bottom right-hand corner.

The same observation can be made of Husain's formidable body of work, as seen through *Husain: The Timeless Modernist*, DAG Delhi's new exhibition which began on October 26 and shall be open to viewers until December 14. A co-founder of the Progressive Artists' Group, Husain was one of the most important Indian artists of his lifetime. *The Timeless Modernist* takes viewers through the various phases of his long and distinguished career, focusing on the man's key influences, motifs and preoccupations.

A lot of Husain's paintings were deeply informed by religious themes. A series of works in the exhibition are inspired by Hinduism, Islam, Christianity, Judaism, Buddhism and so on—what shines through is Husain's indomitable humanism and deep sense of compassion for India's full spread of religions. At the same time, he was also very invested in secular ideas of art and education, as evident in works like 'Bharat Bhagya Vidhata' (acrylic on canvas), where you find representations of Mahatma Gandhi as well as 'Bharat Mata', the feminised deity symbolising the country.

"Husain sa'ab's view of India was holistic rather than split into silos of the sacred and the secular, pretty much the way India and Indians see the world in their day-to-day life," says Ashish Anand, CEO and managing director, DAG. "He did not iconograph gods and goddesses but still represented the rivers as goddesses, the thundering of clouds as a stampede of elephants—you couldn't get more



BOOKS

Ways of Seeing

'INDIA'S MOST IMAGINATIVE ART HISTORIAN' **B.N. GOSWAMY** SHARES PITHY OBSERVATIONS ON ART AND RELATED MATTERS IN THIS POSTHUMOUS ANTHOLOGY OF ESSAYS

B. N. Goswamy's gaze on life and art was an x-ray vision. He pierced the person, miniature, manuscript, page, art object, and even situations, with a knowing smile on his lips.

Ruminations is a wise, borderless tome, where the whole world is under his artistic gaze. Although the blurb talks only of India and South Asia, the book goes to many corners of the world because BNG went there with all his six senses. So, the correlations between the different continents also feature in this marvel of a book put together by Usha Bhatia comprising his regular columns in *The Tribune*, Chandigarh. It is odd that her contribution goes unacknowledged.

Goswamy's wayward, eclectic mind whose inquisitiveness could follow the wind into the smallest alleys where something lay undiscovered for connoisseurs, can only make for a most fascinating read. But even if the readers visited the same places and saw the same things, it is unlikely they could deduce so much.

There are 125 short essays on a host of art-related subjects. But, as the master alerts readers quite early in the book, "The riches of this magical world of 'noble artificiality' are for those who prepare themselves with care before entering it." Published in old-world style, typeset in Stempel Garamond LT Pro, though the illustrations are in black and white, BNG's words evoke and fill in the colours from our passive memory

This book is a collection of BNG's columns in *The Tribune*, put together by Usha Bhatia after his death